

My Claude Usage Strategy

A personalized model & effort-level playbook for a 60-Day AI Challenge (B.Tech IT Student Edition)

Claude.ai gives you two independent dials next to the send button: the **model** (Haiku / Sonnet / Opus) and the **effort level** (Low / Medium / High / Max). The real unlock for a daily 60-day challenge is right-sizing both dials per task, instead of using the strongest setting for everything.

Recommended Primary Model: Claude Sonnet 4.6

Why This Model Fits Me

- Handles coding, debugging, explanations, and resume/career writing at a consistently high level — covering all four of your main use cases.
- Fast enough for daily back-and-forth practice without long waits between questions.
- More usage-limit friendly than Opus, which matters when chatting daily for 60 days straight.
- Strong enough that Opus becomes the exception for hard problems, not the everyday default.

When to Use Haiku

Use it as your fast lane for low-stakes, high-volume asks: quick syntax checks, one-line lookups, summarizing a short article, or rephrasing a sentence. Don't use it for anything you need to deeply understand — it's tuned for speed, not depth, and doesn't have an adjustable effort dial since it's already optimized to be quick.

When to Use Sonnet

Your default for almost everything: learning new concepts (OS, DBMS, CN, AI/ML), writing and debugging code, prompt-engineering practice, building projects, polishing resume bullets, practicing interview answers, and daily research summaries. If unsure which model to pick — pick this one.

When to Use Opus

Reserve it for genuinely hard moments: stuck on a tough DSA/algorithm problem after two Sonnet attempts, designing capstone/hackathon project architecture, deep multi-source research synthesis, or a high-fidelity technical/system-design mock interview. It's slower and consumes usage limits faster, so it should feel like a deliberate upgrade, not a habit.

Recommended Effort Level

Claude.ai's actual effort levels are **Low, Medium, High, Max**. Low and Medium work well for routine tasks and stretch usage further; High offers the best overall balance of quality and speed; Max is the most thorough option, best for difficult or longer-running work.

Level	When to Use It
Low	Quick factual lookups, simple rewrites, syntax checks

Medium	Routine daily learning & coding questions, decent depth without burning quota
High (default)	Concept explanations, debugging, project planning, resume/interview prep
Max	Hardest DSA/system-design problems, final-draft docs, deep research synthesis

Use High most often. Reach for Max only when the task is genuinely hard or the output is something you'll submit/use as-is.

My Personalized Claude Workflow

Task	Best Model	Best Effort	Reason
Daily DSA / coding doubts	Sonnet	High	Needs real explanation, not just an answer
Quick syntax / library lookup	Haiku	—	Speed matters more than depth
Learning new CS concepts	Sonnet	High	Clear, example-driven explanations
Debugging a tricky bug	Sonnet → Opus if stuck	High → Max	Escalate only if Sonnet can't crack it
Resume bullets / LinkedIn polish	Sonnet	High	Needs nuance, not just grammar fixes
Behavioral / HR mock interview	Sonnet	High	Conversational, iterative practice
Technical / system-design mock interview	Opus	Max	Needs adversarial depth and rigor
Project architecture planning	Opus	Max	High-stakes, multi-step reasoning
Research / comparing technologies	Sonnet (Opus for deep dives)	High	Synthesis across sources
Quick brainstorm / to-do organizing	Haiku	—	Low-stakes, high-frequency
Writing reports / documentation	Sonnet	High	Long-form structured writing
Toughest competitive coding problems	Opus	Max	Correctness-critical, multi-step logic

Biggest Mistakes I Should Avoid

- Defaulting to Opus + Max for everything — drains usage limits fast with no real quality gain on simple tasks.

- The opposite mistake: sticking with default settings on a genuinely hard problem instead of raising the effort level.
- Copy-pasting AI-generated code without understanding it — this will sink you in technical interviews.
- Trusting AI-generated facts without cross-checking, especially for exams or research.
- Starting a brand-new chat for every small question instead of keeping related work in one thread so Claude retains context.

Final Recommendation

If I could use only ONE model and ONE effort level: Claude Sonnet 4.6 at High effort.

This combination covers roughly 90% of what a B.Tech student needs daily — strong enough to teach concepts properly, debug real code, and write polished career content, while staying fast and economical enough to sustain daily use across a full 60-day challenge. Step up to Opus only for the rare moment a problem is genuinely too hard for it — not as a routine.

Prepared as part of a 60-Day AI Challenge mentorship plan.